



User migration in the Twitter diaspora

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Abstract

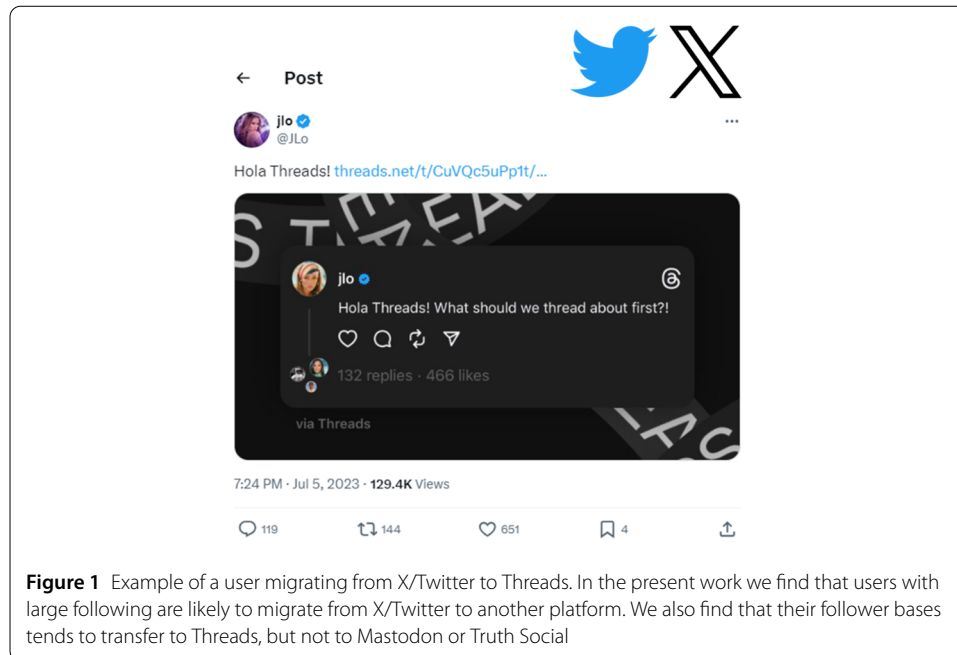
User migration across social media platforms has accelerated in response to changes in ownership, policy, and user preferences. This study examines the migration from X/Twitter to emerging alternate platforms such as Threads, Mastodon, and Truth Social. Using a large dataset from X/Twitter, we analyze the extent of user departures and their destination platforms. Additionally, we investigate whether a user's follower count on X/Twitter correlates with their follower count on other platforms, assessing the transferability of audience size. Surprisingly, our findings indicate that users with larger followings on X/Twitter are more likely to migrate. Moreover, follower counts on X/Twitter are strongly correlated with those on Threads but not with those on Mastodon or Truth Social.

Keywords: Reputation; Social media platforms; Migrations

1 Introduction

The history of online social media has been marked by a cyclical pattern of rise and fall, with users seeking new spaces for expression and engagement. From the early days of MySpace and Facebook, from Digg to Reddit, and from Vine to TikTok, the landscape has witnessed numerous transitions [13, 14] as users migrate in search of fresh experiences and communities. More recently, the once-dominant X/Twitter has faced a notable exodus of users to emerging services like Mastodon, Truth Social, and Threads. The acquisition of Twitter by Elon Musk in October 2022 sparked widespread attention and debate. Musk's vocal advocacy for free speech absolutism has garnered support from some users, while others have raised concerns about the potential proliferation of unreliable information. This divisive shift has prompted many to migrate elsewhere. Consider the example from Fig. 1, where the musician and actor Jennifer Lopez is one of many who have moved from X/Twitter to a new service in recent months. Conversely, the deplatforming of certain individuals from mainstream networks has triggered strong reactions from their followers. In response, these banned users and their supporters have moved to environments that align more closely with their political ideologies, often bringing their audiences with them. This shift raises intriguing questions about the transferability of users' audiences as they transition between social spaces. How does one's influence and standing on a particular site carry over to new digital environments? Exploring these dynamics offers valuable insights into the evolving nature of online discourse, interaction, and community formation.

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To understand social media dynamics, such as the transference of audience size [1, 6], people often look to metrics like follower counts and engagement levels, which are often associated with reach and influence in online communities. Because reputation and influence are commonly inferred from visible audience metrics, some users may strategically manipulate their audience metrics to enhance their online presence, often through tactics like purchasing followers. However, these audience dynamics may not seamlessly translate across platforms, leading to disparities in users' online visibility and influence. As a result, individuals may enjoy high levels of visibility on one platform while having minimal presence on another, raising questions about the portability and reliability of follower-based influence across different online ecosystems.

In the present work, rather than comparing the identities of followers migrating between platforms, we focus on the scale of followers gained on the new platform. We define *follower transfer* as the efficacy of a user's follower base from one platform in establishing an audience on another platform.

Audience metrics like followers, likes, and shares serve as one measure of a user's visibility and influence. These metrics serve multifaceted roles on the internet, particularly within social media platforms, where they are utilized for various purposes such as political engagement [30, 33], financial endeavors [32], and spreading rumors [24]. An individual's online standing, representing how they are perceived by the public, is pivotal in fostering trust and, consequently, wielding influence. Figures like Donald Trump, who transitioned to Truth Social after being banned from Twitter; Elon Musk, known for his Cryptocurrency endorsements [11]; and Pope Francis, who has actively engaged with the public through social media platforms [4], illustrate the role of online influence as a primary indicator of leadership within social media. The actions of such leaders wield considerable influence over social media discourse and can trigger migrations between platforms. Consequently, scholars have extensively explored methods to identify these leaders

and their followers [29], seeking to forecast migration patterns that may impact audience distribution across platforms.

Previous studies have delved into the underlying motivations driving platform migration, exploring the factors that pull users towards new platforms while simultaneously pushing them away from existing ones [14, 34, 35]. Additionally, research has investigated the typical behaviors exhibited by migrants during such transitions [14], as well as the ramifications of *deplatforming*—the removal of users from social media platforms for violating community guidelines or platform rules [27]. Insights from these research efforts help developers and policymakers design platform features and policies that enhance user retention and manage the transition of audience metrics more effectively.

1.1 Migrations, deplatforming, and its effect on audience

Central to the study of these migrations is the push-pull theory [35], which posits that various factors influence individuals' decisions to transition from one platform to another [10]. These factors may include platform design, toxicity levels, moderation policies, and the presence of one's social circle or community [7]. However, the specific motivations behind migrations can vary greatly depending on the ideological stance and moderation practices of the platforms involved. For instance, migration to platforms like Truth Social may be driven by ideological alignment, whereas the appeal of platforms like Mastodon may stem from its decentralized governance model and the value placed on privacy and open-source principles. These differences are not trivial; they shape the dynamics of user migration and influence how reputation is perceived across platforms.

Platform acquisitions also play a pivotal role in migration dynamics, as exemplified by Elon Musk's acquisition of X/Twitter [16], which spurred research by Zia et al [36]. Their analysis of Twitter migration to Mastodon, a decentralized social media platform, revealed that 2.26% of users completely left Twitter following the acquisition, and users who remained active on both platforms exhibited distinct posting behaviors. Similarly, Matthews et al [20] investigated the migration of Twitter users to Parler, highlighting its significant impact on political polarization despite its limited user base. Prior research by Kumar et al [19] laid the groundwork for identifying migration patterns, paving the way for subsequent studies such as that by Jeong et al [14] to further identify migration dynamics. These migrations are deeply shaped by platform ideologies, with users seeking platforms where their values and views are more likely to be protected and promoted. This pattern contrasts with the motivations behind migrating to less ideologically charged platforms such as Mastodon, where users may be driven by technical features or a desire for a less toxic environment.

When individuals or groups violate platform rules, social media companies may resort to *deplatforming* as a means of enforcement [5, 15, 26, 31]. Notably, in 2019 several influential figures faced removal from Facebook and Instagram due to involvement in organized hate and violence [12, 23]. Subsequently, some of these individuals reported significant impacts on their follower count, reputation, and overall influence [21]. In response to such bans, affected users often migrate to platforms aligned with their political ideologies, exemplified by movements to platforms like Gab [18] or Telegram [3, 27]. These platforms may provide a more welcoming environment for those marginalized by mainstream moderation policies, but this migration also underscores the ways in which reputation and influence can be reframed in the context of different ideological spaces. In this study, we

define reputation as a combination of two observable features: an account's audience size (*i.e.*, follower count) and its tenure on a given platform.

Thus, while reputation on one platform may not directly transfer to another, especially when platforms are ideologically distinct, users often bring with them the expectation that their influence will be recognized within the new ecosystem. However, this expectation can be complicated by differences in platform culture, governance, and the ways in which reputation is constructed and recognized across these digital spaces.

1.2 Research questions

In light of recent developments, such as the ownership change at X/Twitter and the emergence of competing platforms like Threads, Mastodon, and Truth Social, we aim to address the following key questions: (*RQ1*) How many users have migrated away from X/Twitter, and what alternate platforms have they chosen? (*RQ2*) How does a user's audience, measured by followers and interactions, transfer when users migrate between social media platforms?

To address these questions, we utilize a comprehensive dataset gathered from X/Twitter to identify users who have transitioned to Threads, Mastodon, and Truth Social. We track the migration patterns of these users and analyze the transfer of their follower base across platforms following their migration. Our findings indicate that: (*RQ1*) Users with a substantial following on X/Twitter are more inclined to migrate to other platforms. (*RQ2*) Their audience, as measured by the number of followers, tend to transfer to Threads, but not to Mastodon or Truth Social.

These findings suggest that user migration is not random, and that the nature of the destination platform influences the transferability of the follower base. The inclination of high-follower users to migrate underscores the potential for significant shifts in influence across services, while the varying degrees of following transfer across platforms point to differing user behaviors and platform characteristics.

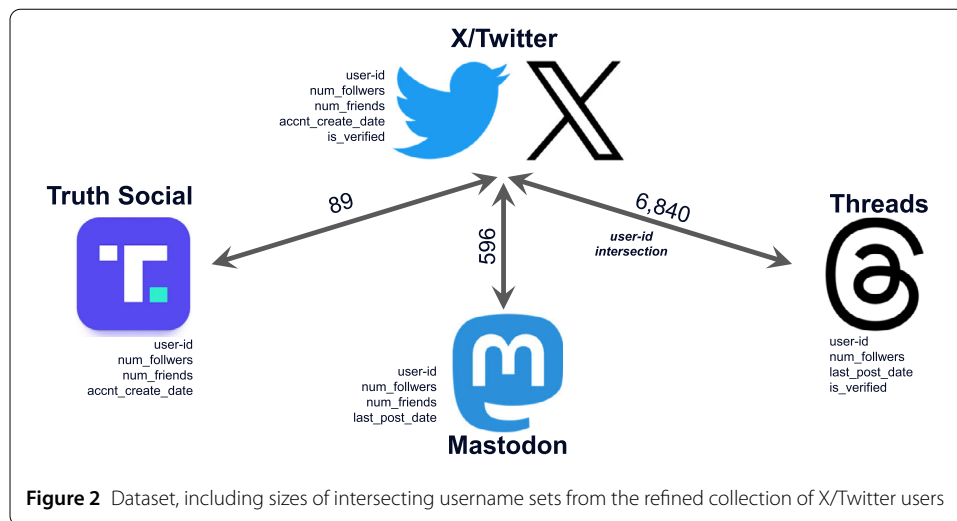
2 Methods

Our initial dataset of 117,919 accounts was created by merging datasets from X/Twitter, sourced from open-source datasets McKelvey et al [22] and Bejda [2]. From this initial pool of accounts, we found usernames that were an identical match to usernames from Threads, Mastodon, or Truth Social. The union of these accounts contained 9545 accounts.

We rescraped the Twitter data, commencing on April 5, 2024, and continuing until April 9, 2024, utilizing the union list of accounts. Through this process, we identified 7430 users that still had accounts on the Twitter platform—only a small fraction of these accounts (<1%) remained active on Twitter. These 7430 accounts constitute the focal point of our analysis, representing migrated users who have transitioned from Twitter to alternate platforms. The sets of matching accounts are illustrated in Fig. 2.

To establish a control group, we selected 10,000 users from the original 117,919 X/Twitter dataset. Subsequently, we conducted a thorough rescraping of this control set and identified 6468 users who still had accounts on Twitter, but did not have any accounts on the alternate platforms.

In summary, the treatment group contained 7430 X/Twitter accounts that also had an account of the same username on at least one other platform; the control group contained 6468 X/Twitter accounts that did not have an account on one of the other platforms.



The process of matching users between platforms presents a significant challenge to the validity of this methodology. While it provides a practical approach for identifying users across multiple platforms, it inherently relies on the assumption that users maintain consistent usernames across different social media accounts. However, this assumption is not always valid, as individuals may choose different usernames or aliases on various platforms for reasons such as privacy concerns, branding strategies, or simple availability. As a result, users with inconsistent usernames across platforms may not be accurately captured in the dataset. Despite this limitation, any bias introduced by exact username matching is consistent between the treatment and control sample methodologies. Therefore, although our results are not exhaustive, we do not anticipate significant constraints in our statistical analysis.

2.1 Collecting migrations

X/Twitter We used the ScrapFly API [28] to collect data from X/Twitter. During this collection process, we also identified the user's follower count, friends count, account creation date, and verification status.

Threads From the refined X/Twitter dataset ($N = 117,919$) we queried Threads for user information using the same ScrapFly API. We also collected user information including follower count, verification status, and last post date.

Mastodon The same process of using the ScrapFly API was used to collect data from Mastodon. This effort identified 1019 accounts with matching usernames on both platforms. We also collected user information including follower count, friends count, and the last post date of each user.

Truth social For the Truth Social platform, rather than scraping the site directly, we used an existing dataset [9] containing information on 454,000 users. From this dataset, we identified 380 users with the same usernames as those in the refined Twitter dataset. For each user, we gathered data on follower count, friends count, and account creation date.

3 Results

We collected a representative sample of ($N = 14,816$) X/Twitter accounts. This was comprised of 8347 X/Twitter accounts that had created an account on at least one other platform. This is compared to 6469 X/Twitter accounts that did not open an account on any other platform.

3.1 Migration analysis

Migrants tend to keep their X/Twitter accounts Our initial hypothesis presumed that users migrating to alternate platforms would be less inclined to retain their X/Twitter accounts because platform migration might entail closing one account as another is opened. However, contrary to this hypothesis, our analysis, conducted with a χ^2 test, revealed that those who migrated were more likely to retain their X/Twitter accounts than users who did not migrate ($\chi^2(1, N = 14,816) = 160.16, p < 0.001$).

These unexpected findings raise questions about the underlying factors influencing user behavior during platform migration. One potential explanation could be the phenomenon of social media churn, wherein users who migrate between platforms tend to be more actively engaged on social media overall compared to those who do not migrate. However, without access to additional data, such as users' activity levels across various platforms, we cannot conclusively determine the underlying cause of this discrepancy.

X/Twitter accounts with higher follower counts are more likely to migrate Next, our goal was to investigate (*RQ1*) whether X/Twitter accounts with larger audiences were more likely to migrate to alternate platforms.

Our data collection of X/Twitter accounts also retrieved information on follower counts, account creation dates, and the number of accounts each user follows. We normalized the creation dates against October 28, 2022, the day Elon Musk took control of Twitter, where positive values indicate accounts created before this event.

We used logistic regression to analyze migration patterns, with the dependent variable indicating whether a user migrated to another platform (encoded as 1 for migration and 0 for non-migration). Our analysis revealed significant correlations between migration and several factors: the number of followers, the number of accounts followed, and tenure on X/Twitter. Specifically, each additional follower was associated with a 20% increased likelihood of migrating to another platform. Additionally, longer tenure on X/Twitter slightly predicted migration, while the number of accounts followed showed a weak inverse correlation. The odds for each variable are illustrated in Fig. 3.

Complementing this quantitative analysis, we conducted a brief qualitative review of influential individuals with extensive followings (over ten million followers) who left X/Twitter following Elon Musk's acquisition. Many cited their discomfort with changes to the platform, notably the return of Donald Trump and a policy shift that placed future legal actions under the jurisdiction of Texas courts [25], perceived as conservative. Celebrities, such as Elton John, expressed their concerns related to the change of policy which, based on their beliefs, "allow for misinformation" [17], while Gigi Hadid indicated the platform to be a "cesspool of hate" [25] and Toni Braxton noted that Twitter "is no longer a safe space". Figure 4 provides screen captures of some of these comments.

Likewise, the Guardian newspaper left Twitter due to concerns that "X is a toxic media platform and its owner has been able to use its influence to shape political discourse."

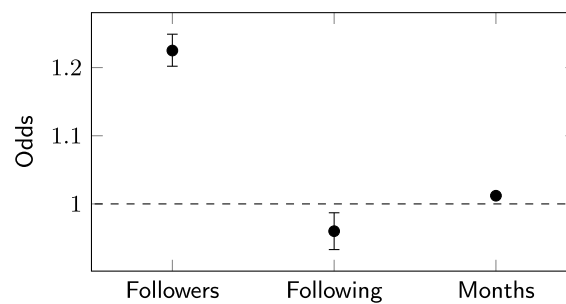


Figure 3 Odds plot (with 95% confidence intervals) illustrating the probability that a user migrates to another platform for the number of followers, number of users following, and number of months spent on X/Twitter. Users are approximately 20% more likely to migrate to another platform for each additional follower ($p < 0.001$)

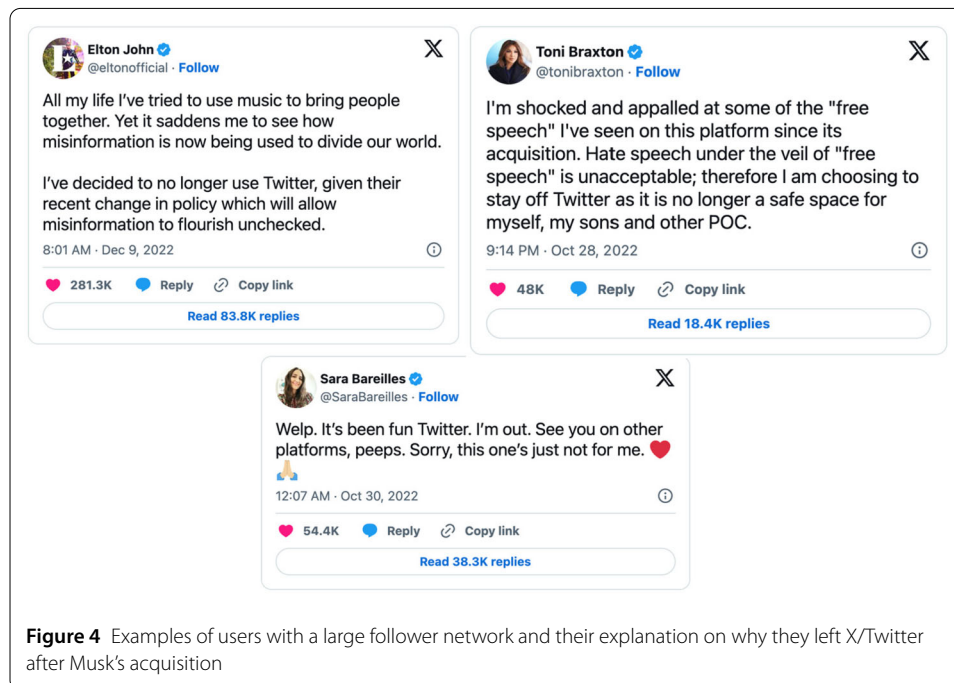
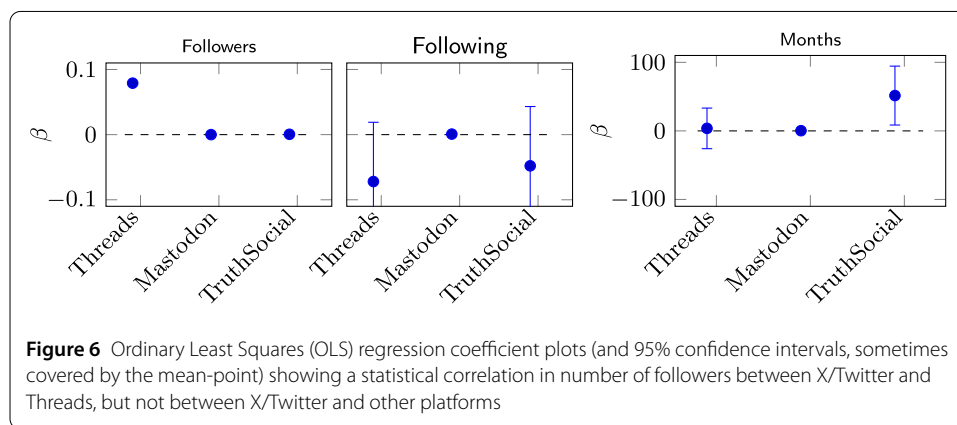
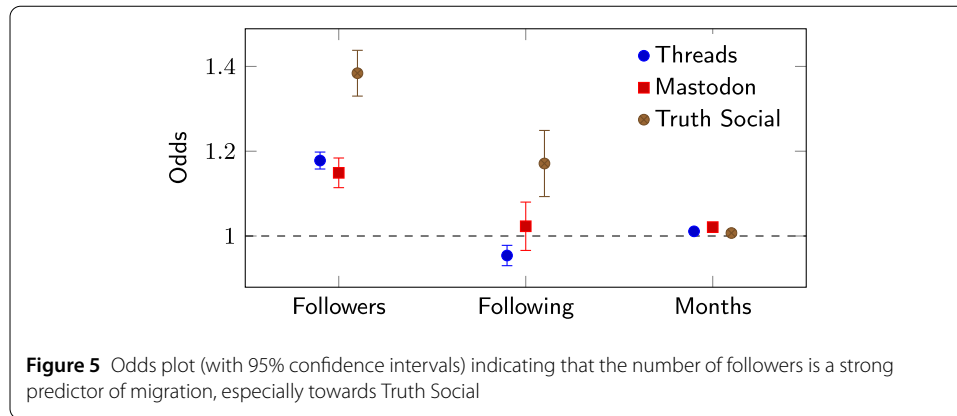


Figure 4 Examples of users with a large follower network and their explanation on why they left X/Twitter after Musk's acquisition

National Public Radio (NPR) also left X/Twitter after its accounts were labeled “state-affiliated media” [8]. Other high-profile users and brands, such as Shonda Rhimes and Volkswagen, transitioned to platforms like Threads or Bluesky without completely abandoning their X/Twitter accounts. However, this migration often resulted in a social cost, as some users experienced a loss of followers after leaving the platform.

Where did users migrate? Next, we performed a deeper analysis of the migration patterns by examining migration patterns to individual platforms: Threads, Mastodon, and Truth Social. Unlike the binary analysis in the previous analysis, which focused on whether users migrated or not, this analysis aimed to understand where users migrated to.

Recall that this set of usernames was contingent upon their presence on X/Twitter. Within this set, we identified 7740 users on Threads, 1019 users on Mastodon, and 380



accounts on Truth Social. Given these numbers, we ask: what is the relationship between users' activity on X/Twitter and their propensity to migrate to each respective platform?

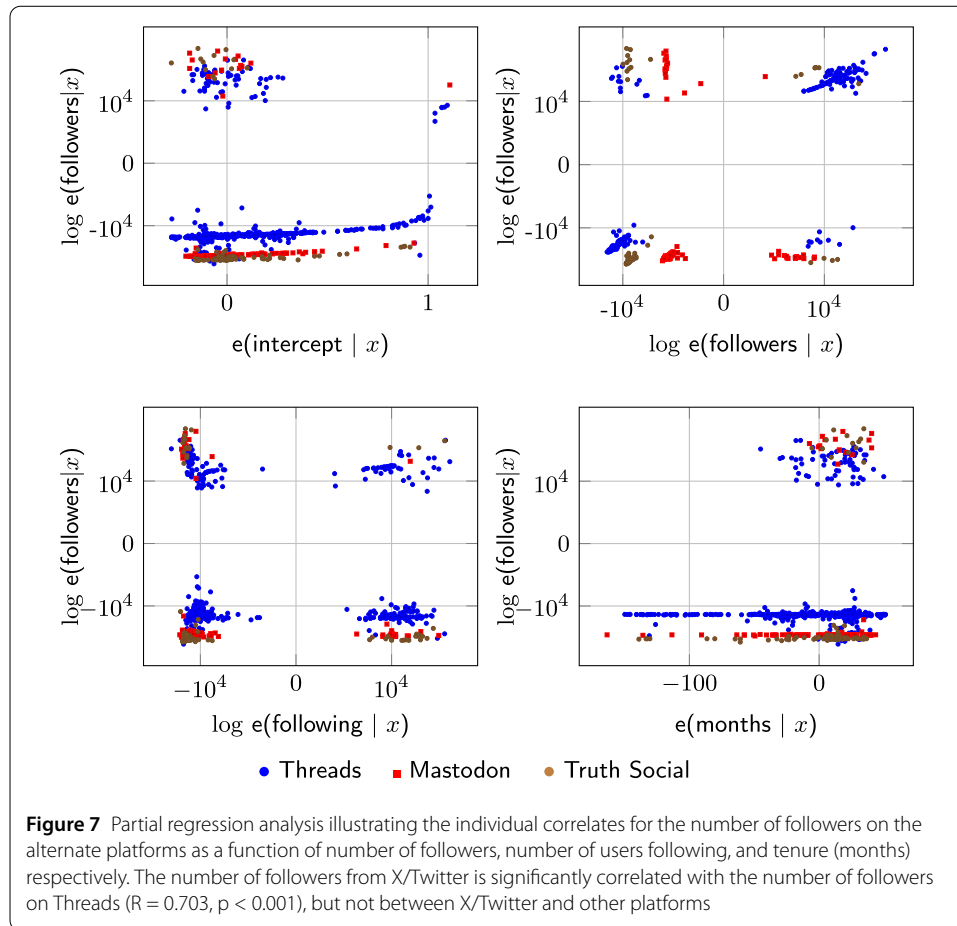
We again employed logistic regression analysis to identify correlates for migration, considering variables such as the number of followers, the number of accounts the user follows, and their tenure on Twitter. The odds for each variable for each platform are illustrated in Fig. 5. We find that the number of followers serves as a stronger predictor of migration to Truth Social compared to the other platforms. However, it is essential to note that this observation should be tempered by the relatively low number of users who migrated to Truth Social overall (see Fig. 2 in the Methods).

3.2 Audience analysis

The previous section focused solely on the likelihood of users migrating to alternate platforms. Next, we ask: (RQ2) When users do migrate, does their follower-base transfer with them?

To investigate this, we conducted Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression analyses for each group of users migrating to different platforms. Our hypothesis is that a strong correlation exists between the number of followers a user has on X/Twitter and the number of followers they accumulate on the platform to which they migrated.

Regression coefficients (β), along with their corresponding 95% confidence intervals, are illustrated in Fig. 6. We find a robust and statistically significant correlation in the number of followers between X/Twitter and Threads, but this following transfer was not found between X/Twitter and Mastodon nor between X/Twitter and Truth Social.



Finally, Fig. 7 illustrates partial regression plots for each independent variable against the dependent variable while holding the other variable constant. Each subplot represents the correlation between the number of followers on Threads, Mastodon, Truth Social and one independent variable (such as the number of followers on X/Twitter or the number of months on X/Twitter) while controlling for the effects of other variables in the model.

We used Tukey HSD to perform a posthoc test on the pairwise comparisons. We find that number of followers did transfer from X/Twitter to Threads; that is, the number of followers of a user on X/Twitter is significantly correlated with the number of followers on Threads ($R = 0.703$, $p < 0.001$). However, findings were not statistically significant for Mastodon and Truth Social ($p = 0.865$ and $p = 0.912$ resp.) nor for the number following and tenure variables.

4 Discussion

The study reveals several key findings regarding user migration patterns, follower transfer, and platform-specific differences in the context of social media dynamics: (1) users who migrate to alternate platforms were more likely to maintain their presence on X/Twitter compared to those who did not migrate; (2) the number of followers on X/Twitter positively correlated with the likelihood of migration to alternate platforms, indicating a relationship between user follower count and migration behavior; (3) users tended to preserve

their follower count when transitioning from X/Twitter to Threads, but not to Mastodon or Truth Social.

The implications of this study extend to various stakeholders in the social media landscape. First, platform developers and administrators can benefit from understanding the dynamics of user migration and follower transfer, enabling them to tailor platform features and policies to better retain users and manage follower transitions. Additionally, policymakers and regulatory bodies may find insights from this study valuable in shaping policies related to data portability, user privacy, and platform competition. For users, the study highlights the importance of audience management and the potential impact of migration on their online presence and influence.

Despite its contributions, this study has several limitations worth noting. The reliance on username matching as a method for identifying migrated users may introduce biases, as users may have different usernames across platforms or may not be captured due to variations in usernames. Second, this study compares the number of followers among usernames, not the actual sets of followers; although it is unlikely, it could be that the followers on one social media platform are disjoint from the set of followers on another. Third, the study focuses primarily on quantitative measures of audience transfer, such as follower counts, overlooking qualitative aspects such as engagement and content quality. Additionally, the study's scope is limited to X/Twitter, Threads, Mastodon, and Truth Social, potentially overlooking trends and behaviors on other platforms. Finally, the study's analysis is based on observational data, limiting the ability to establish causal relationships between migration and audience transfer.

Future research in this area could explore several avenues to address the limitations of this study and expand our understanding of social media migration and audience transfer. For example, qualitative studies could provide deeper insights into the motivations and experiences of users who migrate between platforms, shedding light on the underlying reasons for migration and the dynamics of audience transfer. Furthermore, longitudinal studies could track users over time to examine how their audience evolves after migration and whether any initial patterns persist or change over time.

In conclusion, this study sheds light on the complex dynamics of social media migration and audience transfer, revealing insights into how users navigate between platforms and maintain their online identities. By analyzing user data from multiple platforms and employing statistical techniques, we have uncovered patterns of migration and identified factors influencing audience transfer. While our findings provide valuable insights, there are still many unanswered questions and avenues for future research. Understanding these dynamics is crucial in an era where social media is changing dramatically and playing a large role in shaping public discourse.

Abbreviations

RQ1, Research Question 1; RQ2, Research Question 2; API, Application Programming Interface; OLS, Ordinary Least Squares; HSD, Honestly Significantly Different.

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Author contributions

KR and TW conceptualized the idea. KR, DA, GL, and FK performed the data collection. TW performed the data analysis and wrote the paper.

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Data availability

The Truth Social datasets analyzed are publicly available at <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.7531625>. The Twitter/X datasets analyzed during the current study are not publicly available due to license agreements, however, the accounts from the treatment and control groups are available from the corresponding author on reasonable request.

Declarations

Ethics approval and consent to participate

This research was reviewed by the Notre Dame Institutional Review Board and determined not to be human subjects research.

Consent for publication

All authors consent to publish this work.

Competing interests

The authors declare no competing interests.

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